



The Hands Don't Listen

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 The first bowl I tried to throw collapsed under my own thumbs. I had walked into the studio at forty-one carrying twenty years of being good at things, of running the meeting, of finding the right word on deadline, and I sat down at the wheel certain the clay would behave for someone who had behaved so well at everything else. It did not. It went sideways, then off the wheel entirely, then onto the floor, where it sat looking like exactly what it was, which was a lump of mud handled by a man whose hands had never once been asked to do anything but type.

2 My instructor put her hands over mine and walked them through the pull, fingers on my fingers, the way you teach a child to hold a pencil [Anecdote]. I was embarrassed by how much I needed that. The research is unsentimental about why: a guide who physically moves a learner's hand builds the muscle memory that words cannot, and a beginner with no structure forms bad habits early that are murder to unlearn later. I knew none of this going in. I thought I would watch a video.

3 Here is the part that stung. The very thing that made me good at my job was the thing slowing me down at the wheel. [Antithesis] Adults who come to a new craft carrying real expertise in some adjacent field often crawl through the novice stage slower than a teenager would, because the frameworks that serve them everywhere else interfere with learning the actual fundamentals. My brain kept trying to manage the clay the way I manage a project. The clay does not take direction. My studio has good light, which has nothing to do with anything.

4 I had also assumed I was further along than I was. I was sure I was a decent beginner, maybe better than decent, the kind who gets it quickly; I was not [Juxtaposition]. There is a well-documented reason confident beginners feel that way. In 1999 two psychologists named Kruger and Dunning showed that people in the bottom quarter of a skill rate themselves around the sixty-second percentile while actually landing near the twelfth, because the very incompetence that sinks them also hides itself from them. I had been, without knowing the term, a perfect case.

5 The early weeks did give me one honest gift: visible progress, session over session, the deep ordinary pleasure of watching your own hands get less stupid. [Imagery] A wall that stood up. A rim that did not wobble. And then the plateau, which no amount of cleverness shortened, because the brain consolidates this kind of learning quietly during deep sleep and on its own schedule, not mine. I learned that competence is not a thing you have and carry from room to room; it is local, built slowly in one place, and it does not travel. [Antithesis] The years at my desk bought me nothing here. What I want for you, whatever room you have been good in for a long time, is the nerve to be the worst person in a different one, and to find out your hands were waiting all along to be that bad at something.

Devices, and why they are here:

Anecdote (paragraph 2): “My instructor put her hands over mine and walked them through the pull, fingers on my fingers, the way you teach a child to hold a pencil”

The hand-over-hand lesson is a single lived scene standing in for the whole truth about how physical skill is taught; it earns the writer's standing by showing the moment of needing help rather than asserting humility, which is the register's core ethos move.

Antithesis (paragraph 3): “The very thing that made me good at my job was the thing slowing me down at the wheel.”

The contrast between what makes the writer good at work and what slows them at the wheel is balanced into one sentence so the irony lands hard; it crystallizes the piece's governing tension between expertise and rank-beginner status.

Juxtaposition (paragraph 4): “I was sure I was a decent beginner, maybe better than decent, the kind who gets it quickly; I was not”

Placing the writer's felt certainty of being a good beginner directly beside the flat 'I was not' sets self-image against fact without forcing them into matched grammar, dramatizing the gap the Dunning-Kruger data then explains.

Imagery (paragraph 5): “The early weeks did give me one honest gift: visible progress, session over session, the deep ordinary pleasure of watching your own hands get less stupid.”

Concrete sensory pictures, a wall that stood up and a rim that did not wobble, carry the satisfaction of early progress through things the reader can see rather than through an abstract claim about motivation.

Antithesis (paragraph 5): “I learned that competence is not a thing you have and carry from room to room; it is local, built slowly in one place, and it does not travel.”

The deliberate re-specifying of competence as local and untransferable is the organizing move of the close; it turns an ordinary word into the lesson the writer hands the reader, which is how this register lands meaning.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the fifth paragraph, the writer recasts competence as something 'local, built slowly in one place,' that 'does not travel' primarily to
 - A) praise the discipline of pottery over the abstract work the writer did at a desk
 - B) redefine an ordinary word so the essay's lesson arrives as a discovery rather than an assertion
 - C) introduce a second argument about sleep that the rest of the paragraph develops
 - D) prove through evidence that adults cannot learn new physical skills after a certain age
2. In context, the closing wish that the reader find 'the nerve to be the worst person in a different one' best supports which characterization of the writer's tone?
 - A) encouraging and self-implicated, offering the reader a hard-won lesson as a gift rather than an order
 - B) urgent and cautionary, warning the reader away from risks the writer regrets taking
 - C) neutral and clinical, reporting research findings without any personal stake
 - D) wry and detached, treating the reader's struggles as material for gentle mockery

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer B. The redefinition of competence is the organizing move of the close, reframing a familiar word so the reader feels shown a truth rather than argued into one. The option about adults being unable to learn inverts the passage, which insists the early weeks produced real visible progress, so the writer never claims learning is impossible. The option about sleep mistakes an inert supporting detail for a new line of argument; the sleep fact explains the plateau and is not developed further. The option about praising pottery over desk work imports a ranking the passage never makes, since the writer mourns lost transfer rather than elevating one craft above another.

2. Answer A. The close hands the reader a blessing drawn from the writer's own failure, warm and self-implicating, which is the register's signature exit. The wry-and-detached reading misreads the affection as mockery; the writer turns the joke on himself ('less stupid'), not on the reader. The urgent-and-cautionary reading inverts the stance, since the writer wishes the reader into the risk rather than away from it. The neutral-and-clinical reading ignores the heavy first-person stake and the direct address, treating a confiding voice as a research summary.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer claims that 'competence is not a thing you have and carry from room to room.' Where in the piece does the personal narrative earn that claim, and would the claim land as hard if the writer had simply stated it without the pottery scenes?
2. The essay folds research findings (muscle memory, the Dunning-Kruger effect, sleep consolidation) into a first-person story. How does putting a study inside a confession change the way you receive the study, compared with reading the same fact in a textbook?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The claim about competence not traveling is earned by the accumulation of scenes that grow in stakes: first a single collapsed bowl, then the instructor's hands over his, then the realization that his professional frameworks actively interfere, then the misjudged self-assessment. By the time the writer states that competence is local, the reader has watched twenty years of desk expertise buy him nothing at the wheel, so the abstract claim arrives as the name for something already proven. Stated cold at the top, the same sentence would read as a motivational slogan; placed last, it reads as a verdict the evidence forced.
2. Embedding the Dunning-Kruger finding inside the writer's own overconfidence changes it from a fact about other people into a fact about the reader and the writer both. In a textbook the study is something that happens to anonymous test-takers in the bottom quartile. Here the writer says he was 'a perfect case,' so the bias stops being a curiosity and becomes a mirror. The confession lowers the reader's defenses, which is exactly the register's strategy: a vulnerable 'I' makes the uncomfortable research easier to accept as true of oneself.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a first-person reflection on taking up pottery as an adult beginner after a career built on intellectual work. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-developed essay, analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to develop a meaning about what competence is and what it costs to begin again. In your response you should: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports that reasoning, attending to the writer's use of personal narrative, the contrast between expertise and beginner status, and the late redefinition of the word competence; and demonstrate control over the elements of composition.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may label the instructor's hands-over-hands moment a metaphor because it feels symbolic; it is a literal remembered event used as evidence, which makes it an anecdote, not figurative language. Tie this to the marked Anecdote: the device is the lived scene itself, not a comparison.
- Students may call the third-paragraph contrast (what makes him good at work is what slows him at the wheel) a paradox or simple repetition. It is antithesis: two genuinely opposed ideas set in balanced form. The opposition is real, not just two topics side by side.
- Students may read the closing line as a directive or command ('be the worst person'). The grammar is a wish ('What I want for you... is the nerve'), not an imperative; the register hands the lesson over rather than ordering it. Mistaking wish for command misreads the whole tone.
- Students may treat the detail about the studio's good light, or the sleep-consolidation fact, as load-bearing evidence for the thesis. The light is deliberately inert and the sleep fact is a quiet aside; recognizing that not every true detail serves the argument is part of reading the passage honestly.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches Style (Skill Category 7) by showing how diction, the late redefinition of a key word, and a confiding first-person tone serve a controlling meaning, and Reasoning and Organization (Skill Category 5) through an escalating sequence of examples that build to a claim. It models how a writer braids verifiable research (muscle memory, the Dunning-Kruger effect) into personal narrative so evidence and ethos reinforce each other, and it gives students a clean case for distinguishing anecdote, antithesis, and redefinition from their look-alikes.